

Chord types

Chords can be categorized into different types, which are determined by the intervals between the notes of the chord. These intervals give each chord type a distinctive sound quality.

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◀ 126–127 Triads

Suspension 140–141 ▶

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Triads

Triads consist of three distinct notes—the root, third, and fifth. There are four basic types of triadic chord—major, minor, augmented, and diminished. Triads can be broken down into two intervals of a third, or one interval of a fifth. The quality of the intervals between the root, third, and fifth of a triad determines to which of these chord types it belongs.

Triad type	Interval between root and third	Interval between third and fifth	Interval between root and fifth
Major	Major third	Minor third	Perfect fifth
Minor	Minor third	Major third	Perfect fifth
Augmented	Major third	Major third	Augmented fifth
Diminished	Minor third	Minor third	Diminished fifth

△ Triad types and their intervals

You can determine the chord type of a triad by observing the quality of the thirds between its individual notes, and the quality of the fifth between its root and fifth.

Triad = Root + Third + Fifth

Color code

	Major third		Perfect fifth
	Minor third		Diminished fifth
			Augmented fifth



C major C minor C augmented C diminished

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◁ C triads

Shown here are major, minor, augmented, and diminished triads, with a root of C. Note the intervals between their notes.



B diminished F# augmented F diminished Ab major G# minor

△ Triads on other notes

Shown here are triads with a root other than C. Like the C triads, these triads are also broken down into two thirds and one fifth, and the quality of these thirds and fifths determines the triad type.